

Week 2 — The Hidden Front Door: Jobs Nobody Told You About

Goal: Discover the entry-level jobs that put you *inside* engineering companies without a degree — the roles that come with tuition reimbursement, mentors, and a ladder. These jobs mostly don't get advertised to 18-year-olds, which is exactly why most 18-year-olds end up in retail instead.

The big idea

There is a whole layer of jobs between “cashier” and “engineer”: **technicians, assemblers, drafters, test operators, quality inspectors, field service techs**. They pay more than retail, they teach you the actual work, the people around you are engineers, and many employers will pay for your degree while you work. Read `resources/entry-level-jobs.md` in this folder first — it's your starting vocabulary.

Part 1: Research

Build a list of **10 entry-level job titles** relevant to ME or EE. For each one:

1. **Job title** (as it actually appears on Indeed/LinkedIn — exact words matter for searching)
2. **What you'd do all day** (2–3 sentences, from real postings, not guesses)
3. **Typical pay in our area** (from actual local postings — record the range and the source posting)
4. **Requirements** (high school diploma? certificate? Which ones say “no experience necessary”?)
5. **Where it leads** (what does this job promote into?)

Where to look:

- Indeed / LinkedIn / ZipRecruiter — search the exact titles from `resources/entry-level-jobs.md`, filtered to your area
- Search tricks: `"no experience" technician`, `"entry level" manufacturing`, `"will train"`
- Local temp/staffing agencies that place in manufacturing (Aerotek, Adecco, Manpower) — their listings show what's really hiring

Rules:

- At least 5 of the 10 must be jobs you'd never heard of before this week.
- At least 3 must explicitly require no experience or say “will train.”
- Every pay number needs a link or screenshot of the posting it came from.

Part 2: Essay (600–900 words)

Prompt: *“The jobs nobody told me about.”*

Requirements:

- Pick the **3 titles from your list you’d most want**, ranked, and defend the ranking.
- Compare the best of them, honestly, to the jobs you’ve been taking: pay, what you learn, where each one is likely to put you in 3 years. Use real numbers.
- Address this question head-on: *“If these jobs are better, why do most people my age not get them?”* (Hint: it’s usually not ability.)

Done when

- ☐ 10-title list complete with sources
- ☐ Essay written
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done